

Comedy Of Manners

The comedy of manners is a distinctive genre within the broader spectrum of dramatic comedy. Originating in the Restoration period of the late 17th century, this genre satirizes the behaviours, fashions, and social conventions of a particular class, typically the aristocracy or upper-middle class. It is characterized by its sharp wit, clever dialogue, and often indecent subject matter. This paper will explore the origins, characteristics, key examples, and lasting influence of the comedy of manners, providing a comprehensive overview of this unique and enduring genre.

The comedy of manners emerged during the Restoration period in England, a time marked by the re-opening of theatres after the Puritan ban during the English Commonwealth. The return of Charles II to the throne in 1660 brought with it a renewed interest in the arts and a more liberal social atmosphere. This period witnessed a flourishing of theatrical productions that reflected and satirized the sophisticated, often decadent, lifestyle of the upper classes.

William Wycherley's "The Country Wife" (1675): This play exemplifies early comedy of manners, with its bawdy humour and sharp critique of marital infidelity and hypocrisy.

George Etherege's "The Man of Mode" (1676): Etherege's play is known for its portrayal of the rakish hero, Dorimant, and its witty exploration of fashionable society.

The comedy of manners is defined by several key characteristics that distinguishes it from other forms of comedy: Satirical Tone: At its core, the comedy of manners is satirical, aiming to expose and ridicule the affectations, pretensions, and superficialities of the upper classes. Through sharp humour and irony, playwrights critique the social norms and behaviours of their time. Witty Dialogue: The genre is renowned for its clever, fast-paced dialogue. Characters engage in verbal duels, showcasing their wit and intelligence. This emphasis on language and repartee is central to the comedy's appeal. Stock Characters: The comedy of

manners features a range of stock characters, each embodying specific societal traits or flaws.

Love and Intrigue: Romantic entanglements and amorous adventures are central to the plots of these comedies. The narrative often involves misunderstandings, mistaken identities, and the pursuit of illicit or forbidden love. Social Commentary: Beneath the humour, the comedy of manners offers incisive social commentary. It critiques the institution of marriage, gender roles, the pursuit of wealth and status, and the hypocrisy of social conventions. Urban

Setting: The action typically unfolds in an urban environment, reflecting the sophisticated and often luxurious lifestyle of the city-dwelling elite.

The Comedy of Manner always seeks to give a real picture of one section of contemporary life, high in social stature with all its sophistication, conversation and an emphasis on careless gaiety. The purpose of this comedy is to give a criticism of social conditions with skillful satiric touches. The successes of comedy of manners depended on the dramatists' capacity to present the unemotional treatment of sex. It is rich with wit and satire and gives the image of the time. The heroine is more important and interesting than the hero in a comedy of manners. The hero of this type of comedy is well born, well dressed and capable of contest of wit. The heroine too, is a paradox of virtues and affectations, and is as self-possessed and witty as her male opponent. They are surrounded by a set of tops, wits, half-wits, who carelessly laugh at social and moral codes. The Restoration comedy of manners aimed at presenting the life of the age. But in doing this, it overstepped the bounds of decency.

Several plays are considered quintessential examples of the comedy of manners: William Congreve's "The Way of the World" (1700): Often hailed as the pinnacle of the genre, this play centres on the romantic and financial scheming of Mirabell and Millamant. It explores themes of love, marriage, and social manoeuvring, all conveyed through sparkling dialogue

and complex character interactions. Richard Brinsley Sheridan's "The School for Scandal" (1777): This play satirizes the gossip and scandal-mongering of high society. Characters such as the hypocritical Joseph Surface and the benevolent Sir Peter Teazle navigate a world rife with deception and intrigue. Molière's "The Misanthrope" (1666): Though French, Molière's work significantly influenced the English comedy of manners. "The Misanthrope" critiques the pretentiousness and superficiality of the French aristocracy through the character of Alceste, who detests social hypocrisy.

Revival and Influence- The comedy of manners saw a revival in the late 19th and early 20th centuries, particularly through the works of Oscar Wilde. Wilde's plays, such as "The Importance of Being Earnest" (1895), epitomize the wit and social satire characteristic of the genre. Wilde's sharp dialogue, clever plots, and satirical edge brought the comedy of manners into the modern era. Modern Influence: The genre continues to influence contemporary playwrights and filmmakers. Modern works that explore social dynamics and the absurdities of modern life often draw on the conventions of the comedy of manners.

The comedy of manners remains a vibrant and enduring genre, offering timeless insights into the complexities and contradictions of human behaviour and social interaction. Its origins in the Restoration period, characterized by a liberal and sophisticated society, laid the foundation for a form of comedy that continues to resonate with audiences today. Through its satirical tone, witty dialogue, and incisive social commentary, the comedy of manners provides a lens through which to examine and critique the foibles of the upper classes. As it has evolved and adapted over time, the genre's capacity to entertain and provoke thought remains undiminished, ensuring its place in the canon of dramatic literature. The enduring legacy of the Comedy of Manners enriches today's narratives, ensuring that its influence endures in the evolving landscape of literature and theatre.

WORK CITED LIST

Congreve, William, " The Way of The World", Bloomsbury Publishing India Pvt. Ltd, Delhi, India, 2015, Print.

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